

Q Why are maternity bras important? Won't my usual bras be OK to wear in pregnancy?

While a few women find that their breasts don't change size significantly during pregnancy, most women do go up around two to four cup sizes during these nine months as their breasts respond to hormonal changes and prepare for milk production.

It's not just your cup size that can increase in pregnancy: your rib cage also expands, sometimes by as much as 4 in (10 cm). The average woman goes up two band sizes in pregnancy. Additionally, your breasts can get heavier and feel tender. All of these changes mean it is important to make sure that your breasts are comfortable and well supported.

Soft and supportive

Wearing a well-fitting, supportive bra during pregnancy can help to prevent or reduce stretch marks, ensure good posture, and relieve tension on your shoulders and back. If your breasts don't change size during pregnancy, your usual bras may suffice, but it is still likely that your breasts will feel more tender than usual, and you will want to make sure that any bra you do wear is comfortable. Good maternity and nursing bras are made from soft materials, are usually nonwired, and offer extra support at the shoulders and back. Maternity bras also have enough stretch and flexibility to allow your breasts some room to continue growing.

Maternity and nursing bras are designed to offer **the right support** and are made of soft, breathable fabrics to provide **maximum comfort**.



Go for a fitting Have a professional bra fitter check your size accurately. She will also take into account how your breasts may change through pregnancy.



Did you know...

Don't guess your new bra size! Many women end up with uncomfortable, poorly fitting bras when guessing—which is the last thing you want in pregnancy or after the birth. You can find professional bra fitters in certain lingerie stores and the lingerie departments of many department stores—and the service is usually free. The fitter will usually measure beneath your bust line and around the bust (over your clothes or with your bra on), ask you to try on a fit bra to gauge your correct cup size, or judge by eye which bra size you need.

Q When do I need to go and get fitted for a maternity bra?

This varies from woman to woman, but as soon as your normal bra starts to feel tight, it's time to get fitted for a maternity bra. If your bra leaves red marks on your skin, it is too tight. It is quite possible that you need to change your bra size two or three times during pregnancy since your breasts continue to grow.

Usually, the end of your first trimester is a good time to check how your bra is fitting, if you haven't already—some women start wearing maternity bras earlier if their bust is too tender to wear their usual bras. During the second trimester, your belly and rib cage start to expand too, so it's worth getting remeasured then as well.

Q I've heard that my breasts will get even bigger after the birth. When should I get a nursing bra?

It's a good idea to buy at least one nursing bra before your baby arrives so you don't have to go shopping right after the birth. Breasts usually stop growing by 36 weeks of pregnancy, so at this point a trained bra fitter can estimate what size your breasts will be after the birth. Your breasts will get bigger when your milk comes in (even if you don't intend to breast-feed), and you might need one or two larger nursing bras. Once your milk supply settles down, your breasts usually get a bit smaller again, so buy bras that you can tighten as your breasts change shape.